

The First Few Minutes: When a Student Loses It

For the adult in the room right after a blow-up. Your response, the room, and the referral.

CLASSROOM MANAGEMENT

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

If anyone could get hurt, get another adult.

Restraint and seclusion are not de-escalation tools. Imminent danger only, trained staff only. [NASP 2021]

YOUR RESPONSE COMES FIRST

1 Lower your voice. Slow your movements.

Few words, clearly. Name the behaviour you expect right now.

SAY

I need you to stop that. We will sort the rest out after.

2 Hold the boundary without piling on.

Decide any consequence after things are calm, logically rather than punitively. Not as part of the blow-up.

3 Give one safe choice.

Loss of control is often part of what the student is reacting to. One real choice beats a string of instructions.

SAY

You can sit here, or stand by the door. Your choice.

DO NOT ASSUME YOU KNOW THE REASON

Blowing up at correction can be a trauma reaction, not defiance.

That does not remove the boundary. It should stop you deciding the cause before anyone trained has looked.

AFTER THE MOMENT, NOT DURING IT

4 Support, then refer.

Offer support yourself, or refer to your counsellor or school mental health professional.

SAY

I want to talk about this later, just us. Not now.

WHEN TO ESCALATE

Severe, or happening repeatedly? Refer it.

You do not need to be certain what is behind it first.

Suspect abuse? Follow your district reporting procedure.

Separately, without waiting on anything above.

What is deliberately not here

Not on this card, on purpose: breathing exercises, calming scripts, or any technique for you to walk the student through. That is treatment, and it is not your job here.

Sources: NCTSN Child Trauma Toolkit for Educators pp.4-6; NCTSN Psychological First Aid for Schools, Core Action 3; NASP 2021 on restraint and seclusion. Full citations in the guide.